



Deck Restoration, Repair & Staining

Professional Process Guide

For homeowners who want a finish that bonds, not one that peels next spring.

Strip & Pressure Wash + Full Sand + Board & Railing Repair + Two Coat Premium Stain or Sealant

PREPARED EXCLUSIVELY FOR

Client Name _____

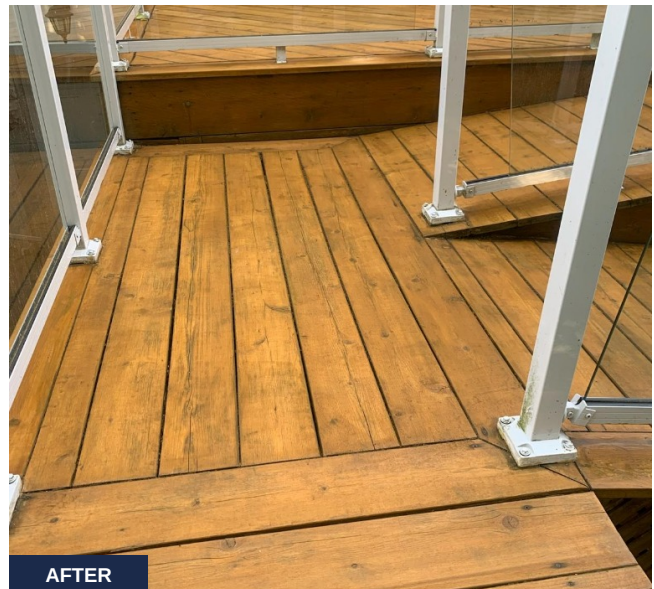
Property Address _____

Phone _____

Email _____

What's Included

A complete deck restoration: pressure wash to strip out dirt, mildew and old failing stain, a full sand so the new finish bonds to bare wood instead of peeling off, replacement of rotten or split boards, tightening or replacement of loose railings and balusters, and two coats of premium stain or sealant. Site protection, plant coverage, full cleanup and a walkthrough with you before we leave.



Full deck restoration, London Ontario. Stripped, sanded, repaired and finished in two coats of premium stain.

Why This Process Matters

Stain Does Not Fail. Prep Does.

When a deck finish peels, flakes or goes blotchy within a year, the stain is almost never the problem. The prep was. Stain has to soak into open wood fibre to work. If it goes down over mill glaze, old failing finish, mildew or a surface that is still damp, it sits on top instead of penetrating. Then the first freeze thaw cycle lifts it right off.

Core Exteriors restores decks in the order that actually works: strip and wash first, sand second, repair third, and only then stain. The sanding step is the one most companies skip because it is slow and dusty. It is also the single step that decides whether your finish lasts two seasons or three years. We do not skip it.

The Complete Package

- Full inspection of boards, joists, ledger board, posts, railings and stairs before quoting
- Pressure wash and chemical strip to remove dirt, mildew, greying and old failing finish
- Complete sand of deck boards, railings, caps and stair treads to open the wood grain
- Replacement of rotten, split or cupped boards with matched material
- Loose railings, balusters, and popped fasteners tightened, re-secured or replaced
- Two coats of premium stain or sealant in solid, semi-transparent or clear finish
- Plant, siding and hardscape protection, full cleanup, and client walkthrough

What You Can Expect: 7 Phases

- Phase 1 - Deck inspection, structural check and before photo documentation
- Phase 2 - Site protection and surface preparation
- Phase 3 - Pressure wash, strip and brightener application
- Phase 4 - Drying window and moisture verification
- Phase 5 - Full sand, board repair and fastener correction
- Phase 6 - Two coat stain or sealant application
- Phase 7 - Final inspection, walkthrough and aftercare

Pricing & Timeline

Every deck is quoted after a free on site walkthrough. Square footage, current condition, how much old finish has to come off, railing complexity, board replacement count and the finish you choose all move the number. The ranges below are what most London area decks fall into so you have a realistic starting point before we visit.

Deck wash and clean only (no stain)	From \$1.50 / sq ft
Full restoration (wash, strip, sand, two coat stain)	From \$4.50 / sq ft
Board replacement (pressure treated, supplied and installed)	From \$12 / board
Railing and baluster repair or replacement	Quoted per section
New deck build (PT, cedar, composite or PVC)	Quoted per project

Restoration pricing depends heavily on how much old finish is still bonded to the wood. A deck that was last done with a solid stain takes significantly more stripping and sanding than one finished with a clear sealant. We confirm exact scope in writing before any work begins.

Typical Timeline

A standard 300 to 400 square foot residential deck is a three day job. Day one is wash and strip. Day two is the drying window plus sanding and repairs. Day three is the two coat finish. The deck needs to be fully dry before sanding and before stain, which is why we build the drying window into the schedule instead of rushing it. Larger decks, heavy board replacement or wet weather extend this and we confirm the schedule at time of quote.

Which Service Does Your Deck Need?

Not every deck needs a full restoration. Every job starts with a free walkthrough so we can confirm the right scope in person, with no obligation. Call 519-712-1431.

IF THIS SOUNDS LIKE YOUR DECK	WHAT YOU LIKELY NEED
Deck looks grey and dull but the finish is not peeling and boards are sound.	Wash, brighten and re-coat. No full strip needed.
Finish is flaking or peeling in sheets, especially on the high traffic areas.	Full restoration. The old finish has to come off before anything new goes on.
A few boards are soft, splitting or cupped, but the frame underneath is solid.	Restoration with board replacement. The frame is the expensive part and yours is fine.
Posts move when you push the railing, or the deck feels springy underfoot.	Structural assessment first. We inspect before quoting any cosmetic work.

Step by Step Process

Below is exactly what happens on a Core Exteriors deck restoration, from the first walkthrough to warranty activation. The

PHASE 1

Deck Inspection & Structural Check

Before we quote a finish, we confirm the deck is sound enough to justify one. Staining a failing structure is money wasted.

1.1 Board Condition Survey

We walk every board and mark anything soft, split, cupped, cracked or badly weathered. Soft spots are probed, because rot that is visible on the surface is usually worse underneath. Each board is flagged as sound, sandable or replace.

1.2 Structural & Ledger Inspection

We check the ledger board connection to the house, joist condition, post footings, and beam attachment. The ledger is the single most common failure point on residential decks in Ontario and it is the first thing we look at.

1.3 Railing, Baluster & Stair Check

Every railing section is load tested by hand. Loose balusters, popped fasteners, worn stair treads and any section that does not meet safe height are identified and quoted.

1.4 Existing Finish Identification

We determine what is currently on the wood: solid stain, semi-transparent, clear sealant, paint or nothing at all. This decides whether we strip chemically, sand aggressively, or both, and it materially affects the quote.

1.5 Before Photo Documentation

Dated wide and close up photos of the full deck, problem boards, railings and stairs. This is your record and our benchmark at final inspection.

PHASE 2

Site Protection & Surface Preparation

Stripper and stain both travel. Protecting what surrounds the deck happens before anything is opened.

2.1 Clear & Stage

Furniture, planters, grills, rugs and any decor come off the deck and are staged clear of the work zone. Nothing gets worked around, because working around furniture is how you end up with unfinished patches.

2.2 Plant & Landscape Protection

Garden beds, shrubs and lawn under and beside the deck are saturated with clean water and covered. Deck strippers are aggressive and runoff is real, so this is not a token step.

2.3 Siding, Trim & Hardscape Masking

Adjacent siding, trim, door thresholds, patio stones and any hardscape are masked. Stain overspray on white trim is permanent and it is entirely preventable.

2.4 Debris & Gap Clearing

Leaves, seeds and debris packed into the gaps between boards are cleared out. Debris left in the joints holds moisture through

PHASE 3

Pressure Wash, Strip & Brighten

This phase removes everything the new finish cannot bond through.

3.1 Controlled Pressure, Not Maximum Pressure

Wood is washed at controlled pressure with a fan tip held at a consistent distance. Too much pressure furs the wood fibre and gouges the softwood between the grain lines, which then telegraphs through the finish forever. Pressure is a tool here, not a weapon.

3.2 Chemical Strip Where Required

Where a bonded solid stain or paint is present, a dedicated stripper is applied and given proper dwell time to break the film. Pressure alone will not remove a bonded solid stain without destroying the wood underneath.

3.3 Wood Brightener Neutralisation

Strippers and cleaners are alkaline and they leave the wood pH high, which darkens it and blocks stain penetration. We apply an oxalic acid based brightener to neutralise the surface, restore natural colour and open the grain. Skipping this is why some stripped decks look muddy after staining.

3.4 Full Rinse

Every surface, plus the surrounding landscaping and hardscape, gets a complete clean water rinse so no chemical residue is left to dry on the wood or the plants.

PHASE 4

Drying Window & Moisture Verification

This is the phase that gets rushed on most jobs, and it is the phase that decides whether the finish holds.

4.1 Minimum 48 Hour Dry

After washing and stripping, the deck needs a minimum of 48 hours of dry weather before sanding, and before any finish is applied. Wood that looks dry on the surface is usually still saturated below it.

4.2 Moisture Meter Verification

We do not guess. Moisture content is checked with a meter across multiple boards, including shaded and north facing sections that dry slowest. Stain goes on when the wood is ready, not when the calendar says so.

4.3 Why Stain Fails on Damp Wood

Stain applied to wet wood cannot penetrate because the fibre is already full of water. It skins over on the surface, traps that moisture underneath, and then blisters and peels as the water tries to escape. This is the single most common cause of a finish failing in year one.

4.4 Weather Window Confirmation

We confirm the forecast before committing to a stain day: no rain for 24 hours before and 24 hours after application, and

PHASE 5

Full Sand, Board Repair & Fastener Correction

Sanding is the step that separates a restoration from a re-coat.

5.1 Why Sanding Is Not Optional

Pressure washing raises the wood grain and leaves the surface furry. Sanding knocks that back down, removes the last of the failed finish, opens the pore structure so stain can penetrate, and gives you a surface that is comfortable to walk on barefoot. A washed but unsanded deck will look fine on day one and shed its finish within two seasons.

5.2 Board Replacement

Boards flagged in Phase 1 are removed and replaced with matched material. New boards are installed with correct spacing and crown orientation so they do not cup or hold water.

5.3 Railings, Balusters & Stairs

Loose railings are re-secured to the posts, wobbly balusters are tightened or replaced, and stair treads are checked and fixed. Handrails and caps are hand sanded because they are the surfaces people actually touch.

5.4 Fastener Correction

Popped nails and proud screws are set below the surface or replaced with coated deck screws. Any fastener sitting proud will catch a sander, catch a foot, and rust through the finish.

5.5 Full Dust Removal

The entire deck is blown down and vacuumed, including gaps between boards and railing corners. Sanding dust left on the surface prevents stain from bonding and shows in the finish as a hazy patch.

PHASE 6

Two Coat Stain or Sealant Application

With the wood clean, dry, sanded and dust free, the finish finally has something to bond to.

6.1 Choosing Your Finish

Clear sealant shows the most wood grain and needs re-coating most often. Semi-transparent adds colour while keeping the grain visible and is the most popular choice. Solid stain gives the most UV protection and hides weathered wood, but it is the hardest to remove later. We walk you through the trade offs before you commit.

6.2 Premium Product Only

We use professional grade exterior wood stains and sealants. Builder grade product does not hold up through an Ontario winter, and the labour to apply cheap stain costs exactly the same as the labour to apply good stain.

6.3 Application Method

Stain is applied by brush, pad and sprayer depending on the surface, and always back brushed into the grain. Spraying alone lays product on top of the wood instead of working it in. Boards are finished end to end in a single pass to avoid lap marks mid board.

6.4 Two Coats, Wet on Wet Where Specified

A second coat goes on within the manufacturer specified window so both coats cure as one film. Vertical surfaces, end grain and cut ends get extra attention because that is where water enters the wood first.

6.5 Railings, Spindles & Stairs

Railings, balusters, post caps and stair risers are finished by hand. These are the details that make the difference between a

PHASE 7

Final Inspection, Walkthrough & Aftercare

We do not leave until the job meets our standard and you have seen the result.

7.1 Quality Inspection Checklist

We verify: even colour with no lap marks or missed sections, all end grain sealed, railings and spindles fully coated, no overspray on siding or hardscape, masking removed, furniture returned, and all debris off the property.

7.2 Client Walkthrough & Sign Off

We walk the deck with you, explain what was done at each phase, and answer questions. If something is not right we correct it before we pack up. You sign off before we close the job file.

7.3 Cure Timeline

Light foot traffic after 24 hours. Furniture back after 48 hours. Rugs, planters and anything that traps moisture should stay off for a full 72 hours minimum.

The Restoration, Step by Step

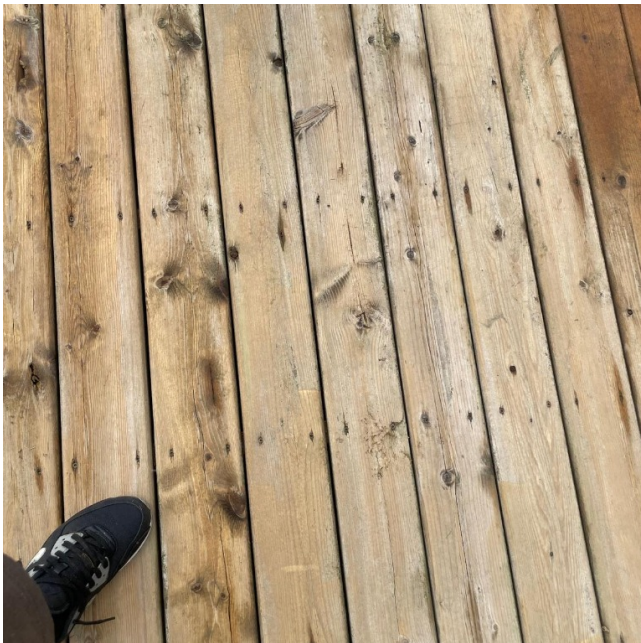
A real Core Exteriors deck restoration in London, photographed at each stage.



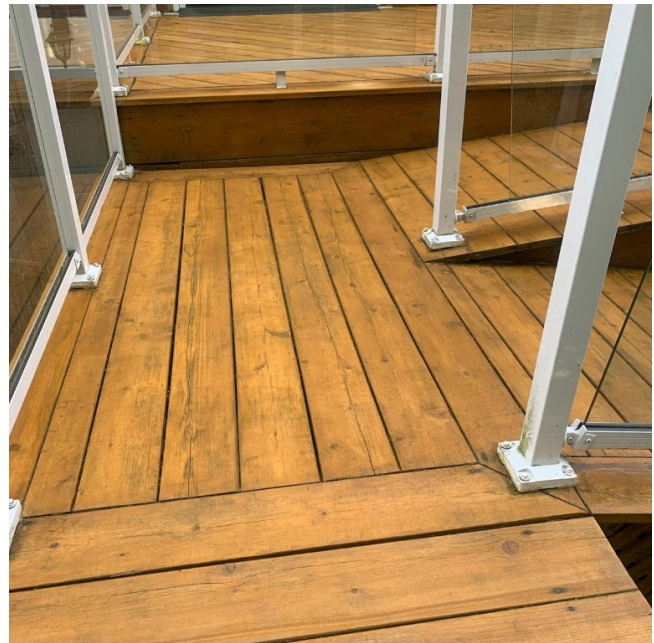
1. Before. Grey, weathered, mildew present and the old finish failing.



2. Washed and stripped. Old finish and greying removed, wood brightened.



3. Sanded. Grain opened and surface levelled so the finish can penetrate.



4. Finished. Two coats of premium stain, railings and spindles hand done.

Questions Homeowners Ask Us

How long will the stain actually last?

Two to three years on the horizontal deck boards, and longer on railings and vertical surfaces because they take far less UV and foot traffic. Decks in full sun with no tree cover sit at the shorter end. When it is time, a maintenance re-coat is much cheaper than a full restoration because the strip and sand phases are far lighter.

Can you just stain over the finish that is already on there?

Only if the existing finish is still fully bonded and you are going with the same product type and a same or darker colour. If it is peeling anywhere, it has to come off, because new stain bonded over failing stain fails with it. We tell you honestly at the walkthrough which situation you are in.

Do you really need to sand? Other quotes I got do not include it.

That is usually the difference in the quotes. Pressure washing raises the wood grain and leaves a furry surface that stain cannot properly penetrate. Skipping the sand makes the job cheaper and faster, and it is the reason those finishes shed within two seasons. We do not quote a restoration without it.

My deck is 15 years old. Is it worth restoring or should I replace it?

It depends entirely on the frame, not the boards. If the joists, posts, footings and ledger are sound, restoration is a fraction of replacement cost even with a dozen boards swapped out. If the frame is failing, we will tell you and we will not sell you a finish on a deck that needs rebuilding.

What colour should I choose?

Semi-transparent is the most common choice because it adds colour and UV protection while keeping the wood grain visible. Solid gives the most protection and best hides an older weathered deck, but it is far harder to strip when the time comes. We bring samples and apply test patches on your actual deck so you are choosing on your wood, not a colour chip.

How long can I not use my deck?

Light foot traffic 24 hours after the final coat. Furniture back after 48 hours. Rugs, planters and anything that sits flat and traps moisture should stay off for 72 hours. We give you exact timing on the day since it moves with temperature and humidity.

What happens if it rains partway through the job?

Rain before stain simply resets the drying window and we push the finish day. Rain after stain is the real risk, which is why we do not apply finish unless the forecast is clear for 24 hours after. If weather turns unexpectedly we assess the affected area and re-do anything compromised at no charge.

Do you build new decks as well?

Yes. Pressure treated, cedar, composite and PVC, with permits, footings, framing, railings, stairs and built-ins all included in one quote. If restoration is not the right call for your deck we can quote both options side by side so you can compare properly.

Why are you cheaper than the franchise that quoted me?

We are fully independent, so we pay no franchise royalties or corporate marketing levies. That is roughly a 20 percent difference and it comes off your price, not out of the work. We carry \$5M in liability insurance and are fully WSIB compliant.

Guarantee & Next Steps

The Job-Complete Guarantee

We do not leave the site until you are 100 percent satisfied with the work. Your satisfaction is the only measure of success we use. If something is not right, we correct it on the spot before we pack up.

Materials & Products We Use

Professional grade exterior wood stains and sealants, oxalic acid wood brightener, dedicated deck strippers matched to the existing finish, coated exterior deck screws, and pressure treated, cedar or composite replacement boards matched to your existing material. No builder grade finish goes on a Core Exteriors deck.

Aftercare Essentials

- Light foot traffic after 24 hours, furniture after 48 hours, rugs and planters after 72 hours.
- Sweep regularly. Leaves and debris left sitting hold moisture and stain the finish.
- Use furniture pads or feet so nothing sits flat against the boards trapping water.
- Do not pressure wash the deck yourself. It strips the finish you just paid for.
- Clean with mild soap and water only. Bleach and degreasers break down the finish.
- Book a maintenance re-coat at the two year mark. Far cheaper than a second full restoration.

Credentials

- \$5 Million commercial general liability insurance
- Fully WSIB compliant with clearance certificate available on request
- HST registered, London Ontario based, operating since 2022
- Serving London. St. Thomas. Strathroy. Dorchester and surrounding communities

Ready to Book Your Free Walkthrough?

We will inspect the structure, identify every board that needs replacing, confirm what finish suits your deck, and prepare a written quote before any work begins. No obligation and no pressure to book on the spot.

Luke Cairns | 519-712-1431 | coreexteriors@gmail.com | coreexteriors.ca